

KF11 Meeting Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

During the past few weeks, we have been learning the **Maranatha Meditation**.¹ Try to practice this meditation in the morning and again later in the day; then, when faced with life’s problems, you will already be trained to step back and find your center. You will have the skill to be able to collect yourself and connect to God. Put a memo on your phone or on your daily schedule as a reminder to practice.

This month we will learn a new meditation practice called the **SALT Process**. Nancy designed this tool to help members explore stressful events. You cannot cast your real fears onto God if you avoid knowing what those fears are. The **SALT Process** will help you examine your fears and cast your cares onto Him.²

The SALT Process

1. S is for Skin

Let’s begin with the mindfulness posture. Lift the top of your head toward the heavens and plant your feet or tailbone on the earth. Let your shoulders hang from that upright structure. Breathe. *(Pause)* Focus your mind on your body as the breath moves in and out. *(Pause for 20 seconds)* Notice where your skin is. Simply notice it. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Now, gather your attention to observe only what is within your own skin. If your mind wanders outside your skin—into the future, the past, a problem, or toward someone else—gently guide your mind back to what is happening in *your* body within *your* skin. Observe your experience without judgment, and breathe for thirty seconds. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. A is for Assess

Bring to mind an event or an outcome that you have judged as evil. If you can’t recall anything, think of something good and try to imagine what the lack of that thing would be like. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* As you consider this bad or evil situation, assess on a scale of one to ten how uncomfortable you are about it. An assessment of ten would mean that you feel very distressed and have judged the situation as very bad. Observe how your body feels. Is there fatigue, tension, or restlessness? *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Where in your body do you feel these things? *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Continue to breathe and observe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

If you find that the tension or discomfort in your body is too uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting. After taking a breath or two, respectfully return to the area that is reacting. Try using a long exhaling breath or a sigh to help your body process what you are feeling. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. L is for Look

Look for the fear behind the judgment. What makes the situation so uncomfortable? You might explore the sensations in your body and ask yourself: *What frightens me about this situation? (Pause) Is my freedom threatened? (Pause) Will this situation cause suffering for myself or for others? (Pause) Does this situation interfere with my pride system or my search for glory? (Pause) How might this situation stir up self-hate?* Ask God to help you identify your fear. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Step back from your assessment of the event as good or evil and just look at the fear that drives that assessment. Part of your training is to learn to simply observe your fear. Fear brings you valuable information. *(Pause)* You might try welcoming the fear. Thank the fear for what it tells you about your Idol Self and for how it motivates you to train toward freedom from fear. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

4. T is for Tell

Tell God about your fear. Tell Him about your Idol's terror and how enslaved you are to fear. Ask Him to help you learn how to overcome your fear by directing your energy toward love. Fear is often based on lies and illusions, so you might ask God to tell you the truth about what you fear. Then, explore your fear with His guidance, and continue to breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

And now, bring yourself back into co-respondence with your environment, that which is outside your skin. Allow what is within you to calmly observe and respond to what is without. Rest, and take a few deep breaths. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

We won't read a hymn or prayer right now. Let's spend a moment just appreciating the effort we have made to learn a new practice. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

This month we will begin exploring KF Confession 3:

We constructed legal systems based on our own assessment of good and evil.

I hope that you have the **Two Paths Worksheet** in front of you. This worksheet helps you see how powerful you are.

How do we create a glorious life? Unfortunately, painful mistakes are part of that process. We cannot possibly know it all, be prepared for it all, foresee it all, and always protect our pride. In KF, we are learning to respond to our mistakes like little children. Little children don't react to their mistakes with hurt pride, judgment, and self-hate. Instead, they take responsibility for their mistakes by trying something new and finding out what works.

We know that we are in pride and self-hate when we avoid taking responsibility for our mistakes by blaming, escaping, or making up virtue stories. When pride and self-hate are driving you toward misoriented reactions and destructive outcomes, the **Two Paths Worksheet** can help guide you into the path of love. You really can learn to build new outcomes in your life.

Let's look together at steps 1–6 in the right-hand column of the worksheet under Judgment. We will use the example of Nancy's own experience to help us learn how to use this worksheet.

1. Outcome

You can begin your journey through this worksheet at any point, but often when trying to untangle a process that has resulted in anxiety, misery, or a mess, you have to begin with the outcome. You know that an outcome is misoriented when it does not reflect the Fruit of the Spirit.³ Nancy found herself making chaotic decisions based on fear, and as James puts it, she was tossed around like the surf of the sea.⁴ The quality of this outcome told her that quite recently she had taken the Judgment Path.

2. Action

Ask yourself the question: *What did I do or avoid that produced this outcome?* As a self-effacing neurotic, Nancy acted by instantly following the advice of someone who had just given her distressing information. She started making decisions before breathing, praying, meditating, or getting counsel. Self-effacing types need to affirm their inferiority by pleasing others, seeking validation from others, and even inviting others to punish them.

3. Rejoicing in the misorientation

This step invites you to explore the emotions that may have compelled you to act. Nancy was feeling intimidated. Self-effacing types need to imagine and focus on evidence that proves how weak and helpless they are. Mastery types need to imagine evidence that supports the illusion that they are blameless, right, in control, and have it all figured out. When that illusion is threatened, they feel rage, revenge, acute anxiety, and contempt. Resigned types try to maintain the illusion that they are free to do as they please, without any adverse consequences. When they feel disappointed, restricted, resentful, fatigued, or locked-down, they use these emotions to justify their dash for freedom. All Idol types, however, can feel defensive, irritable, and unfairly treated, or they may simply go cold when their pride system is threatened.

4. Story

What story have you invented to explain why the situation is good or bad? Self-effacing types will tell the story that other people have more to offer than they do. They believe that they are inferior to others and that they always need support. Mastery types tell stories that demonstrate their own superiority. They must imagine that others are competitive, offensive, or stupid in order to justify their overweening ambition to win or beat others down. When resigned types feel that their freedom is threatened by events, by others, or even by their own feelings, they will tell the story that something or someone is manipulating, coercing, or imposing on them. Their story helps them rationalize their choice to stonewall, push back, or escape. Nancy calls these imagined stories *virtue stories*. We invent virtue stories to justify the emotions that compel us to act. These stories make our misoriented emotions, judgments, and choices seem virtuous, realistic, and of moral value.

5. Judging as good or evil

You are now ready to look at the judgment that you have made. Is this event good or evil? Has it supported or threatened your search for glory?

6. The fear of death and euphoria

Judgments are fueled by the fear of death, especially the death of our pride and dreams. This fear is experienced differently by each Idol type. The chapters in the book *Neurosis and Human Growth* that illustrate your Idol type will help you identify your particular fear of death.⁵ Remember that euphoria, or the escape from the fear of death, also sets us on the Judgment Path. When an event relieves us from the fear of death, we judge it as good and our pride is restored. Euphoria is what you feel when you have been released from your fear.

Once you have worked through steps 1–6, you can use the **FAITH Process** to help you unload your fear of death. In the months to come, you will learn more ways to unload the burden of your fear. No one else can do that for you, and yet we often want others to take responsibility for our fear and unload the burden for us. We want to remind you again that Karis Fellowships is not a need-based ministry. It is an effort-based ministry. Changing your life is no one's responsibility but yours. Unloading my fear is my business, and unloading your fear is your business.

After you have made an effort to unload your fear, you might use your glorious imagination to take the Believe It Path of the left-hand column. Rather than judging something as good or bad, just believe what has happened. State what *is*. Imagine what the story might be if you could lay your judgments aside. What have you learned about yourself, others, or life? What action might you take based on what you have learned? Talk with your Karis Link and enlist the imagination of others to help you. When you learn to take the Believe It Path, God will finally have the chance to show you what marvelous things He can do.

This week, you might try exploring one of your misoriented outcomes using the **Two Paths Worksheet**. Recall your three greatest fears. Could one of them be driving your judgment?

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, teach me to take responsibility for my own fears. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Let's dig a little deeper into KF Confession 3:

We constructed legal systems based on our own assessment of good and evil.

We will now return to the letter from James and look at chapter 1 again. We learned that having our faith or trust tested is essential for our growth. If we want to grow, we will welcome life's events because they show us where we have put our trust—whether in God or in our Idol Self.

God brings into our lives people and situations that stir up areas that need examination and healing. One of these areas is the area of wealth. We can be rich in money, skill, time, health, relationships, antecedents, and natural gifts. We can also be poor in any of those areas. Our tendency is to judge wealth or poverty as good or evil.

This is Nancy's paraphrase of **James 1:9–12**.

⁹To the siblings of small resources, rather than feeling shame, let them proclaim their trust from their high place of living within limitations. ¹⁰The wealthy can proclaim their trust by refusing to use their resources to circumvent their limitations; they can choose to live as lowly creatures, because the reality is that the wealthy are subject to decay, just like a flower of the grassland. ¹¹For we know that the sun rises with burning heat that withers the grass; its flower falls, and its attractive façade is utterly destroyed. Even so, while going along in his or her way, the person of large resources will also fade away, just like all creatures. ¹²Favored is the one who endures life's experiments, whatever their circumstances may be, so that being approved as genuine and trustworthy that one will receive the crown of life, which God has promised to those who are loving Him.

Take a deep breath.

God has told us that this world is passing away, and when we judge wealth or poverty as good or evil, we are not seeing things from God's perspective.⁶ We often judge wealth as good because we perceive wealth as the absence of limitations. What bliss for the Idol Self to be free from limitations! Our Idol then develops an attachment to wealth as a desirable and even a necessary thing. Poverty might be defined as an extremely limited lifestyle. That makes poverty particularly evil for the Idol. The limitations imposed by poverty or loss of wealth do not allow our Idol to feel superior or free.

Perhaps we find ourselves stuck in poverty in some area of our lives. We may even choose not to access real resources because having resources is taboo and we need to feel poor. We then use our perceived poverty to justify the demands we make on ourselves and on others.

When our identity is wrapped up in wealth or poverty rather than in the love of God, we believe that we deserve accommodation from others and from life. This attachment to accommodation creates anxiety and makes us vulnerable to disappointment and resentment. When we are not accommodated, our sense of significance and self-worth is threatened, and our pride is hurt. In our search to fulfill our imagined glory, we have put our trust in some kind of wealth or in the superiority of entitlement, and when those things elude us, we feel cheated.

James warns us that when we attach to something as vulnerable as the grass, which is passing away, we set ourselves up for all kinds of disappointments. Fear of loss stagnates our lives and numbs our creativity, driving us into all kinds of misorientation and resulting in more disappointment and loss. We live in a world that is passing away, but we are depending on it for our joy. How crazy is that? As eternal creatures, we just weren't designed to attach to this material world.

Humble circumstances, or poverty in some area, can be glorious because people with fewer resources are invited to develop more trust in God. These people learn to be grateful for everything. They learn to live within limitations and are highly motivated to change their lives. Their hunger is stronger than their fear.

James teaches us quite a bit about wealth in his letter. He's not against wealth, but he is against how we use wealth to support the Idol Self. The wealthy—those who are rich in money, abilities, possessions, family background, or experiences—are to glory in humiliation by choosing to participate in the limitations experienced by the rest of the world. They can take part in activities that put them in the place of a learner, and they can acknowledge their position as fellow creatures by demonstrating trustworthiness and active

kindness. They must circulate gifts *in proportion to their resources*, or else their souls will stagnate into fear and self-hate.

In both poverty and wealth, persevering in the development of the True Self is the key to success. Through persevering in this process, we gain practical experience both in the world and in our relationship with God. This practical experience grows our self-confidence and gives us greater authority in whatever socio-economic mission field we are designed to serve. Who gives us the stamp of approval when we persevere in the development of the True Self? Certainly God, but we too can approve the outcomes of an oriented life.

Hopefully, you will experience both poverty and wealth in many areas of your life, and at different times. Poverty can cleanse and prune the soul, while wealth can support more opportunities for exploration and service. Your goal is to be complete and lack nothing. By running your race with endurance, whether in poverty or in wealth, you are learning to wear your crown of life, in this life, with authority and love.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, teach me to glory in both poverty and wealth. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider an area of poverty or wealth in your life. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

Feelings

As you *consider an area of poverty or wealth in your life*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush feelings or thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Breathe, and hold your experience up to the light as you *consider this area of poverty or wealth in your life. (Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe, and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing when you *consider poverty or wealth in your life*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not

understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what deprivation and envy or security and abundance feel like in your body. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this area of poverty or wealth in your life*. Does that feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* Do you judge poverty or wealth as good or evil, as a liberty or a threat? What are your reasons? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Is this judgment a regular pattern in your life? Does your family culture or early training influence your judgments? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something—of the not-knowing, of responsibility, or of someone taking advantage of you? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created us to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you feel when they have *considered poverty or wealth*. You are a human creature and are not alone in your feelings. *(Pause)* When a fear or judgment signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than getting caught up in a story and reacting. Breathe with compassion for yourself and for anyone who mindfully encounters the challenges of poverty and wealth. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

(Optional) Continue to breathe while I test for further integration.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time together to train and heal. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You continue to guide us to our real glory and to the truth. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and design. Help us to circulate with our community, with the rest of the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ John Main, *Monastery without Walls: The Spiritual Letters of John Main*, ed. Laurence Freeman (London: Canterbury Press Norwich, 2006), 32.

² 1 Pet. 5:7.

³ Gal. 5:22–23.

⁴ James 1:6.

⁵ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

⁶ 1 John 2:7.